

COMPANY ROLE SOPs

1. Groundsman SOP

Role Objective

Support the climber and Team Leader, keep the job moving from the ground, protect the property, build and move palm piles efficiently, load the trailer the right way, and make sure chargers, batteries, and small tools stay handled.

Core Responsibilities

The Groundsman is responsible for:

- Watching for falling material at all times
- Protecting the property when needed
- Holding ladders when needed
- Building palm piles efficiently
- Dragging piles to the trailer the right way
- Loading the trailer correctly
- Walking the trailer down as needed
- Raking and cleanup once higher-priority work is handled
- Making sure batteries and chargers are handled properly
- Making sure nothing gets left behind

Main Priorities

1. Safety and awareness
2. Protect the property
3. Support active cutting
4. Build and move piles efficiently
5. Load the trailer correctly
6. Walk down the trailer as needed
7. Cleanup and final check

On Arrival

The Groundsman should:

- Help get batteries on chargers immediately
- Help unload and stage tools
- Help set up protection if needed
- Listen to the Team Leader's plan
- Be mentally switched on from the start

Charging batteries is one of the first tasks on arrival. Do not put it off.

During Active Cutting

The Groundsman must:

- Watch the air at all times for falling limbs
- Stay aware of where the climber is cutting
- Protect the property when needed
- Hold ladders when needed
- Move quickly without getting careless

If limbs are falling, property needs protection, or the ladder needs to be held, that comes before dragging or raking.

Piling System

Do not drag one limb at a time unless there is no other option.

The efficient system is:

- Build as many piles as possible first
- Usually 7–12 limbs per pile, depending on size and type
- Drag those piles to the trailer
- Keep production moving in bulk, not one piece at a time

Sabal vs. Washingtonia / Date Palm Loading

Not all palm piles are handled the same way.

Sabal Palms

- These can be piled up, dragged to the trailer, and dropped right beside the trailer first

- Once enough material is there, it can be loaded into the trailer efficiently

Washingtonia and Date Palms

- These should not be dropped beside the trailer
- Once the pile is picked up, it should go straight into the trailer
- The pile should not touch the ground again before being loaded
- This saves time, avoids extra handling, and keeps the spikes from becoming more of a problem

Direction of the Piles

Sabal palms

- Stick faces the trailer

Washingtonia or Date palms with spikes

- Stick faces away from the trailer
- Leafy end faces the trailer

That makes pickup and movement more efficient.

Loading the Trailer

Once piles are at the trailer, they must be loaded correctly.

General rule:

- Middle of trailer = vertical loading
- Front and back of trailer = horizontal loading

Do not throw limbs in randomly.

Walking Down the Trailer

Trailer management is a major part of the job.

The trailer needs to be walked down regularly, usually every 2–3 trees depending on volume.

When stepping into the trailer:

- Walk the edges
- Stomp the edges down hard
- Focus on shoving material down to the sides

If the trailer gets full later in the day, one ground guy may need to stay in the trailer receiving limbs and walking the load down while the other guys feed him material.

That guy should be maintaining the trailer load the entire time.

Cleanup

Raking and final cleanup come after the bulk of the work is moved and loaded.

Do not get stuck raking too early if:

- Active cutting is still happening
- Piles still need to be built
- The trailer is getting backed up
- The property still needs protection

Cleanup is important, but it comes after active production and protection priorities are handled.

Chargers, Batteries, and Tools

Ground guys are responsible for helping make sure:

- Batteries are charging as soon as possible
- Batteries are rotated properly
- Chargers are not forgotten
- Tools are not left scattered
- Nothing is left at the property

The last equipment check before leaving includes:

- Chargers
- Batteries
- Saws
- Poles
- Rakes
- Blowers
- Tarps
- Loose tools

One of the most important final checks on every job is remembering the batteries and chargers.

Work Standard

Work efficiently, stay aware, and keep the job moving.

We are not trying to overwork people for no reason, but we are trying to move with pace and purpose. The faster we get jobs done safely, cleanly, and correctly, the better the company performs and the better the pay can stay.

Performance Standard

A good Groundsman keeps the trailer flowing, keeps the property protected, keeps piles moving, and does not need to be told the same obvious things over and over.

Non-Negotiables

- No standing around
- No one-limb-at-a-time laziness when piles can be built
- No sloppy trailer loading
- No forgotten chargers or batteries
- No lack of awareness with falling limbs
- No wasting time on cleanup while higher-priority work is getting backed up
- No leaving without a full equipment check

Field Rule for Everyone

Safety first.

Protect the property second.

Then keep production moving.

Then finish cleanup strong.

And remember: the trailer is a major part of production, not an afterthought.